



DECISIVE MOMENT November 22, 1963 12:30 p.m.

The Death of Kennedy

On Friday November 22, President John F. Kennedy and his wife Jacqueline visited Dallas, Texas, to drum up support for the 1964 US presidential election. As the motorcade drove through Dealey Plaza, at least three gunshots rang out, killing the president instantly. The American people had lost a president they loved, and they had been robbed of their future.

Three days after John F. Kennedy's assassination, the world stopped again, united in grief. The funeral of the 35th president of the United States was watched by a million people lining the procession route, and millions more on television. During his brief time in office, the charismatic young president had come to epitomize the hopes of his nation—belief in a better future and the energetic pursuit of progress. With his murder the mood of bright optimism was shattered.

The assassination became the subject of huge controversy. A lone gunman, Lee Harvey Oswald, was arrested shortly after the shooting and charged with murder. He never came to trial; two days later he was shot dead while in police custody by Jack Ruby, a gangster who later gave contradictory reasons for the killing.

Kennedy's successor, Vice President Lyndon Johnson, quickly established an official investigation into the assassination headed by Earl Warren, Chief Justice of the United States. After a 10-month investigation, the commission concluded that Oswald had acted alone, as had Ruby, and

that there was no conspiracy to kill the president. Many people have refused to accept these conclusions, but no firm evidence has ever come to light to suggest otherwise.

After the assassination, the body of the president was flown back to Washington. It first lay in repose in the East Room of the White House and on Sunday afternoon was taken to lie in state in the Capital Rotunda. A brief memorial service was held. Over the following 18 hours, 250,000 people lined up in near-freezing temperatures to pay their respects.

On Monday the funeral procession returned to the White House and then moved on to St. Matthew's Roman Catholic Cathedral. Heads of state and representatives from 92 countries attended the service. It was at the height of the Cold War (see pp. 406–07), yet even the USSR sent a representative. The Archbishop of Boston led the mass, at which Kennedy's writings and speeches were read. The coffin was taken to Arlington National Cemetery, where Mrs. Kennedy lit an eternal flame over the grave. America now faced an uncertain future without JFK.

A son salutes

Moments after his father's casket was carried down the steps of St. Matthew's Cathedral, John F. Kennedy Jr., whose third birthday it was that day, saluted his father. His uncle Bobby Kennedy, who stands behind him, was himself assassinated just five years later.

“The greatest leader of our time has been struck down by the foulest deed of our time.”

LYNDON B. JOHNSON, US PRESIDENT, NOVEMBER 27, 1963